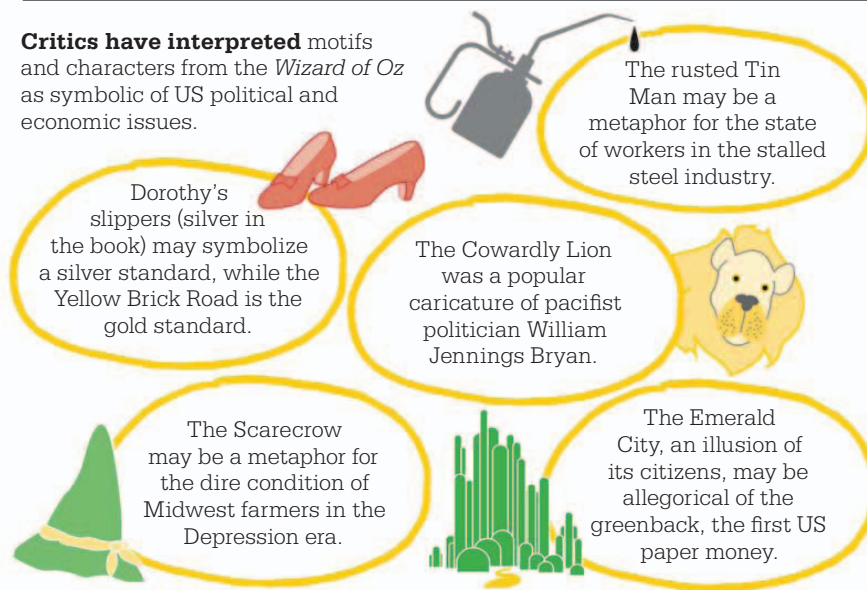


Critics have interpreted motifs and characters from the *Wizard of Oz* as symbolic of US political and economic issues.



characters united by a common goal, here each of our heroes is searching for something they lack. Not fame or fortune, but a personal quality, something they believe will make them whole. Dorothy lacks a home, the Tin Man a heart, the Scarecrow a brain, and the Cowardly Lion his courage.

Each character in the magical world of Oz is introduced to the audience in a location where they are vulnerable, where they think the Wizard's help is the only thing

that can save them. All four of the travelers are on their own "hero's journey," and it is just as important to the viewer that the Tin Man should get a heart as it is to see the Wicked Witch defeated.

Although the movie marked a groundbreaking step in terms of technical achievement, its success also lies in keeping close to the principles of simple storytelling and in its universal appeal as a "quest" movie that follows the rite-of-passage trajectory. The audience

sees the orphan Dorothy undergo a formative transition from a child protected in her home to navigating a new and dangerous world, relying on her trio of friends—symbolically, the emotions, intellect, and courage.

Dream world

Throughout the movie, the action stays intimate even as it becomes epic, and each character is already strangely familiar. The Wicked Witch of the West is a dead ringer for Dorothy's evil neighbor, Miss Gulch, who wants to have Dorothy's dog Toto put down. The Scarecrow, Tin Man, and Cowardly Lion all strongly resemble the farmhands from back home, while the Wizard of Oz appears to be Professor Marvel, a phoney fortune-teller. The most prominent characters in Oz mirror characters back home in Kansas, making it clear that this is Dorothy's dream world.

The movie revels in spectacle, in witches and woods, in lions, tigers, and bears. Yet at its core, it is a tale of friendship and personal growth, and balancing the two may be the secret to its longevity. A memorable story, told with imagination and in vivid splendor, it is a movie that transcends its time. ■



Victor Fleming Director

Born in California in 1889, Victor Fleming was a stuntman before rising through the ranks of the camera department to become a director. His first movie, *When the Clouds Roll By*, was released in 1919. His greatest year was 1939, when he directed *The Wizard of Oz* and *Gone with the Wind*. He was hired as a last-minute substitute on both, replacing Richard Thorpe on the former and George Cukor on the latter. The two movies won several Oscars.

Fleming never again reached those heights, but he went on to make the critically acclaimed *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* and *A Guy Named Joe* (1943). He died in 1949, a year after the release of his last movie, *Joan of Arc*.

Key movies

1925 *Lord Jim*
1939 *Gone with the Wind*
1939 *The Wizard of Oz*
1941 *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde*